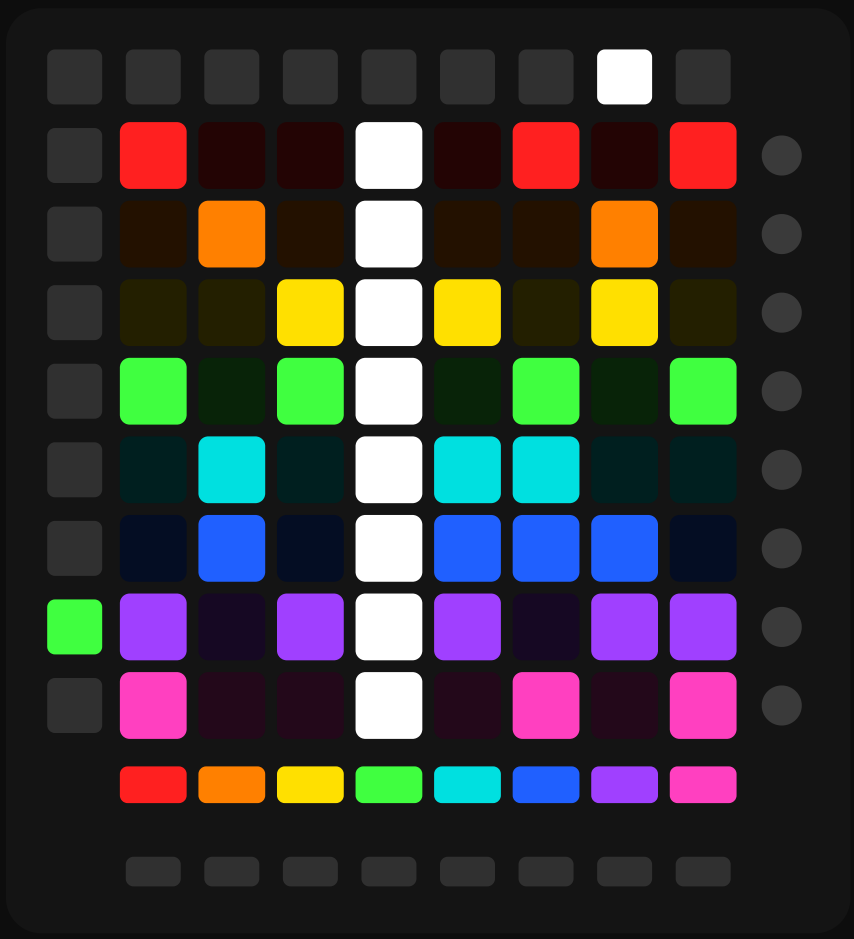
USER GUIDE

8-Track Sequencer

Standalone firmware for Launchpad Pro MK3



Early beta - flash at your own risk. Community firmware based on CoreFW (GPL-3.0). Not made, endorsed or supported by Novation or Focusrite. Launchpad and Launchpad Pro are trademarks of Focusrite Audio Engineering Ltd, used here only to identify the hardware.

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SECTION 1

Introduction

The 8-Track Sequencer turns a Launchpad Pro MK3 into a standalone MIDI sequencer. It runs on the Launchpad itself – no computer is needed once it is installed. Connect synths and drum machines to the two DIN MIDI outputs (or to a computer over USB) and program up to eight parts at once.

Key features

- **8 tracks**, each with its own MIDI channel, output (USB, DIN 1, DIN 2 or both DIN outs), note range, transpose and step rate (1/32 to a whole bar, including triplets)
- **16 patterns** per project, each holding all 8 tracks, of up to **64 steps** per track; switched and chained as a song
- **Chords** – up to 8 notes on every step
- Per-step **velocity**, **gate length** and **probability**
- Tempo 30–300 BPM with **tap tempo** and an on-grid **BPM readout**; **swing** from 50 % to 75 %
- **Live recording** from the pads or an external keyboard, quantised to the nearest step, and **step recording** one note at a time while stopped
- **MIDI thru**: a keyboard plays whichever track is selected
- Sends **MIDI clock**, or can follow an external clock from USB or DIN In
- **32 projects** saved in the Launchpad's memory
- Playback continues while you use the Launchpad's Note mode

What you need

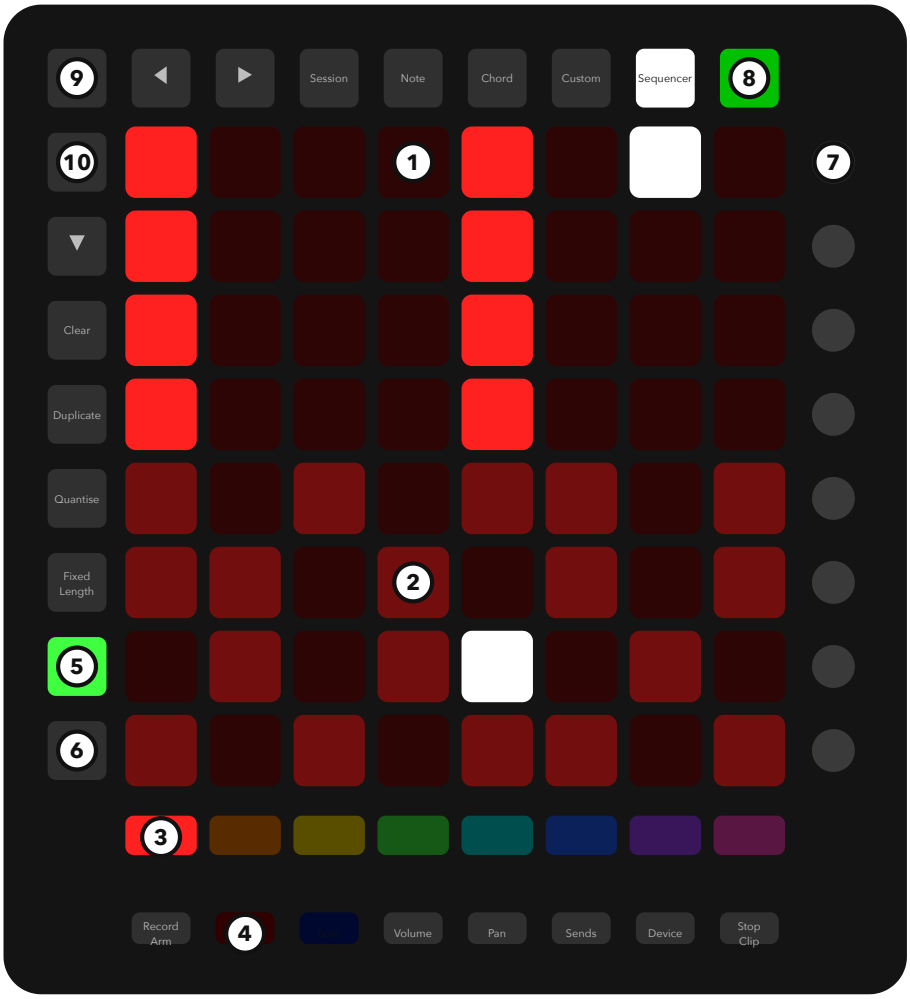
- A Launchpad Pro MK3 running the sequencer firmware (see *Installing the firmware* at the end of this guide)
- Synths, drum machines or a computer to play, connected to **MIDI Out**, **MIDI Out 2** or USB
- Optionally, a MIDI keyboard on **MIDI In** or the USB MIDI port

> **NOTE**
> The second DIN socket on the back of the Launchpad is used as **MIDI Out 2** by this firmware (not as MIDI Thru).

SECTION 2

Overview

The sequencer uses the whole surface of the Launchpad. The top half of the grid shows the steps of the selected track; the bottom half is a keyboard of 32 notes. The coloured row under the grid selects tracks and the row beneath that holds Mute and Solo.



The sequencer with track 1 selected and playing

1. **Step area.** 32 steps of the selected track's current pattern: steps 1–32, or 33–64 after ▶ (top row = steps 1–8 or 33–40). Lit steps play; brighter = louder. The white pad is the playhead.
2. **Note area.** 32 chromatic notes, lowest at the bottom left. Tap a note to hear it and to choose the note new steps get.
3. **Track buttons.** Tap to select a track, hold for its settings. Each track has its own colour.
4. **Mute and Solo.** Arm a mode in which the track buttons mute or solo tracks (see *Mute and Solo*). While a step is held, this whole row sets its gate length.
5. **Play.** Start / stop. Green = internal clock, orange = following an external clock.
6. **Record.** Arm recording: live while playing, step by step while stopped.
7. **Patterns.** Tap to open or close the pattern view (16 patterns on the top two rows).
8. **Projects.** Tap to save, hold to switch project. Green = saved, amber = unsaved changes.

9 **Shift.** Hold for tempo, swing, tap tempo and the clock setting.

10 **▲ / ▼.** Move the note area up or down an octave.

Entering and leaving the sequencer

Press Sequencer to open the sequencer. The first time after power-up, the last project you used is loaded automatically.

Press Note to return to the Launchpad's Note mode. **Playback keeps going** while you play in Note mode – the Sequencer button lights green to show it. Press Sequencer again to come back.

SECTION 3

Getting Started

This walkthrough programs a simple pattern and plays it on a synth connected to **MIDI Out**.

1. Connect your synth's MIDI In to the Launchpad's **MIDI Out** socket, and set the synth to receive on **MIDI channel 1**.
2. Press Sequencer. Track 1 (red) is selected. New tracks send on **MIDI Out**, with the MIDI channel equal to the track number.
3. Tap a pad in the note area. You hear the note on your synth – it is now the note new steps will use.
4. Tap steps 1, 5, 9 and 13 in the step area to turn them on.
5. Press ▷ (Play). The playhead moves across the steps and the synth plays.
6. Hold step 5 and tap two more note pads: step 5 is now a three-note chord.
7. Tap track button 2 (orange), choose a note and add some steps. Track 2 plays on MIDI channel 2.
8. Tap Projects to save. The button flashes white, then turns green.

> **TIP**
> Hold **Shift** at any time to see the current tempo on the grid. Use **Shift + ▲ / ▼** to change it, or tap **Sends** in time while holding Shift.

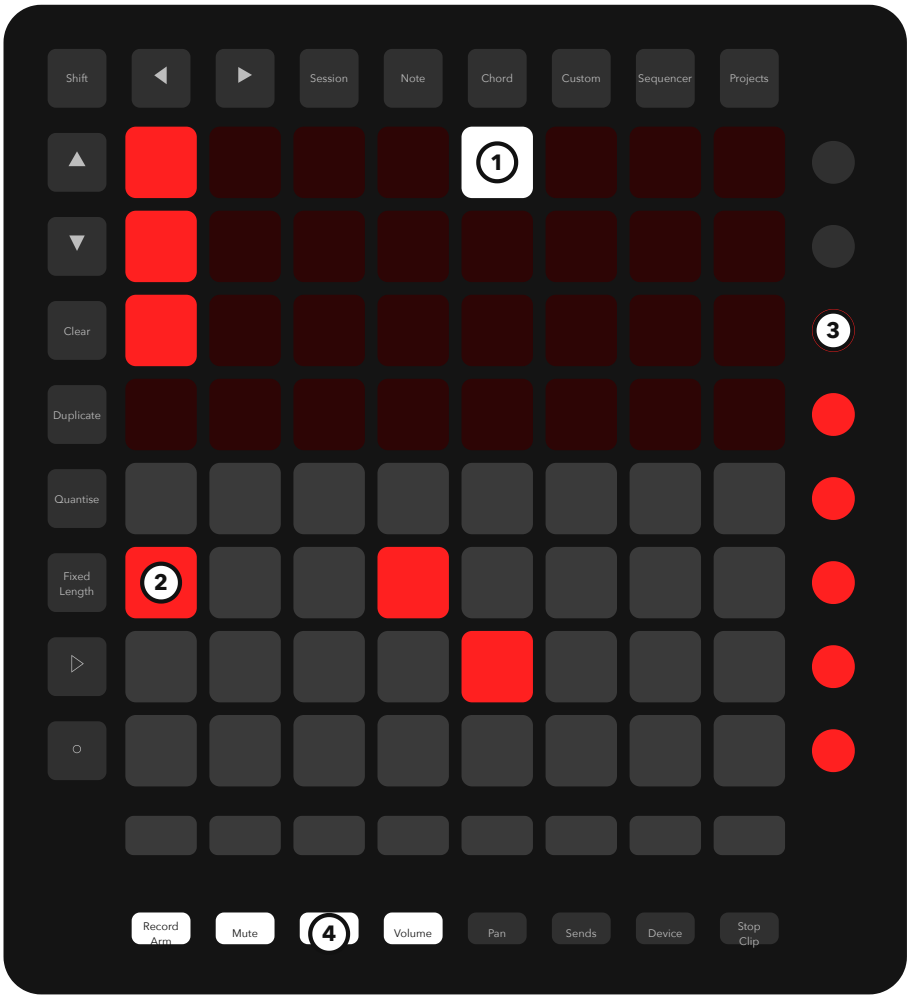
SECTION 4

Programming Steps

Action	Result
Tap a note pad	Choose the note new steps get, and hear it
Tap an unlit step	Turn it on with the chosen note
Tap a lit step and release	Turn it off
▲ / ▼	Move the note area up / down an octave

Holding a step

Hold a step to edit it. While it is held, the note area shows all its notes, the right-hand column shows its velocity and the bottom row shows its gate length.



Step 5 held: a three-note chord, velocity 96, gate 4/8

(1) **Held step.** Shown white while you hold it.

2. **Notes.** The first note pad you tap sets the step's note. Tap more pads in the same hold to build a chord of up to 8 notes; tap a lit note again to remove it.
3. **Velocity.** The right-hand column: top = 127, then 112, 96, 80, 64, 48, 32, bottom = 16.
4. **Gate length.** The bottom row: 1 (Record Arm) = shortest, 8 (Stop Clip) = the whole step.

Probability: hold the step and Shift – the right-hand column then sets how often the step plays: top = always (100 %), then 87, 75, 62, 50, 37, 25, bottom = 12 %.

> **TIP**
> A step you have edited while holding it never turns off when you let go.

Pages: steps 33–64

A pattern can have up to 64 steps; the step area shows 32 at a time. ◀ shows steps 1–32, ▶ shows steps 33–64. The arrow of the page you are on is white; the other arrow is grey when the pattern reaches that page, dim when it does not, and **green while the playhead is on that page**. To make a pattern longer than 32 steps, go to page 2, hold Fixed Length and tap the last step. Projects saved before 64 steps load unchanged.

Copying a step

Hold Duplicate and tap a lit step: it lights **cyan**. Keep holding Duplicate and tap every step you want a copy on. Each copy gets the same notes (including chords), length, velocity and probability. Press ▶ / ◀ while still holding Duplicate to paste on the other page.

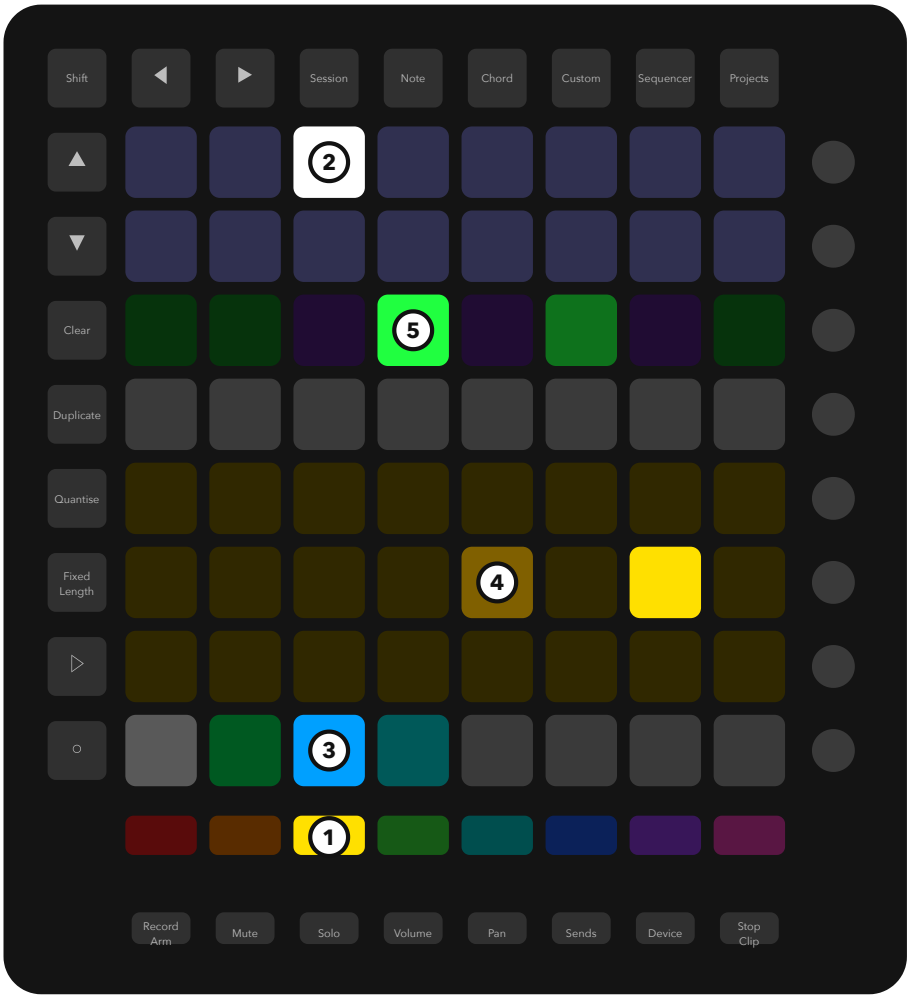
Pattern length and clearing

Action	Result
Hold Fixed Length + tap a step	The pattern ends at that step (1–32, or 33–64 on page 2)
Hold Clear + tap a step	Clear that step
Hold Clear + tap a track button	Clear that track's current pattern (its length stays)

SECTION 5

Tracks

Tap a track button to select it. The step and note areas then show that track, and an external keyboard plays it (see *MIDI Thru*). Hold a track button to change the track's settings.



Track 3 held: MIDI channel 3, output MIDI Out 2, transposed +2, step rate 1/8

1. **Track button (held).** Settings are shown for as long as you hold it.
2. **MIDI channel.** Steps 1–16 (the top two rows) choose channel 1–16; the current channel is white. ▲ / ▼ also step the channel up and down.
3. **Output.** Bottom row of the note area, pads 1–4: USB (white), MIDI Out (green), MIDI Out 2 (blue), both DIN outs (cyan).
4. **Transpose.** Note rows 2–4: −12 … +11 semitones. The dim pad (row 3, pad 5) is 0.
5. **Step rate.** Steps 17–24 (the third row): how fast the track moves through its steps, slowest on the left. Straight rates are green, triplets purple; the chosen rate is bright.

New tracks send on **MIDI Out** with MIDI channel = track number (track 3 = channel 3).

Step rate

Each track can step at its own speed against the shared tempo, for example a bass line at half speed under a 16th-note hi-hat. Hold the track button and tap a pad in the third row; the slowest rate is on the left:

Pad	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24
One step =	1 bar (1/1)	1/4	1/4 triplet	1/8	1/8 triplet	1/16 (default)	1/16 triplet	1/32
Speed	1/16×	¼×	⅜×	½×	¾×	1×	1.5×	2×

All tracks start together when you press Play, so tracks at different rates stay in line. Swing only affects tracks at 1/16; other rates play straight. Gate lengths scale with the step, and live recording uses the selected track's rate. The rate is saved with the project.

Mute and Solo

Mute and **Solo** in the bottom row arm a mode for the track buttons. The armed button flashes; press it again to disarm.

Press	Then tap a track button to
Mute (flashes red)	Mute or unmute it at once
Solo (flashes blue)	Solo or unsolo it at once
Shift + **Mute** (flashes red and white)	Mute or unmute it when its pattern next starts from step 1
Shift + **Solo** (flashes blue and white)	Solo or unsolo it when its pattern next starts from step 1

While Mute is armed, the track buttons show unmuted tracks in their colour and muted ones dark red; while Solo is armed, soloed tracks in their colour and the others dark. A queued change flashes the track button white until it happens; tap the track again to cancel it. When stopped, a queued change happens at once.

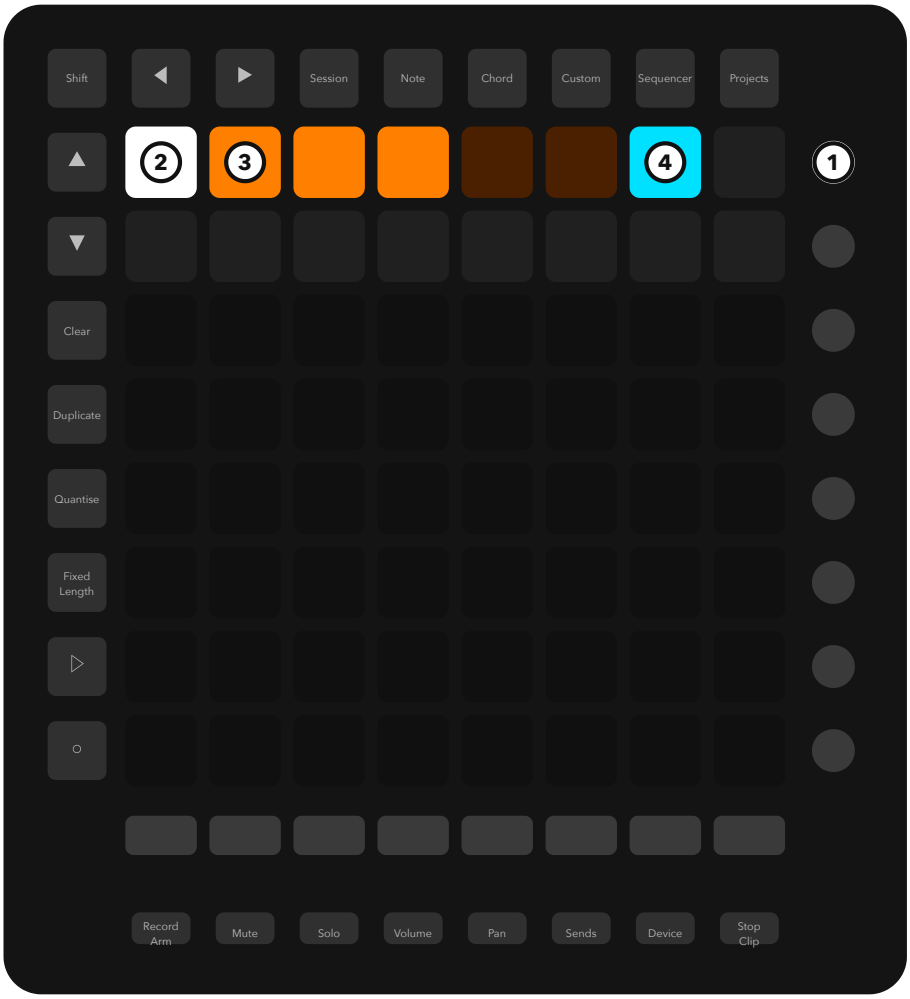
When any track is soloed, only soloed tracks play; a muted track stays silent even if soloed. Outside Mute and Solo mode, tracks silenced by mute or solo show darker. Mutes and solos are saved with the project.

SECTION 6

Patterns and Chains

A project has **16 patterns**. A pattern holds **all 8 tracks**, and every track is always on the same pattern: switching pattern switches the whole song.

Tap **Patterns** to open the pattern view: the button lights white and the top two grid rows show the 16 patterns (1–8 on the top row, 9–16 below). The view **stays open** until you tap **Patterns** again, so both hands are free to pick and chain patterns. You can also hold **Patterns**, tap a pattern and let go: the view then closes by itself.



Pattern view: pattern 1 playing, chain 1–4, pattern 7 queued

1. **Patterns.** Tap to open / close the view (white while open).
2. **Current pattern.** White.
3. **Chained.** Orange: part of the chain. Dim orange = has notes; dark = empty.
4. **Queued.** Cyan: starts when the playing pattern ends.

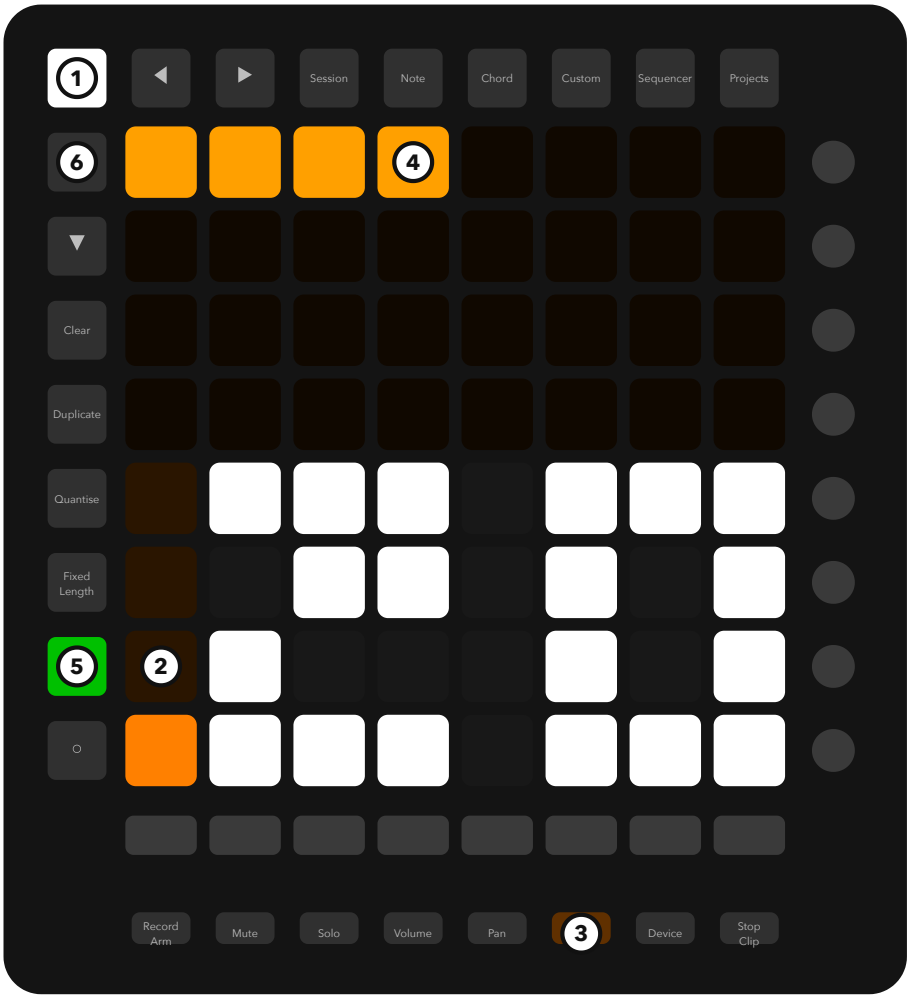
In the pattern view	Result
Tap a pattern	Switch to it – at the end of the playing pattern, or at once when stopped
Hold a pattern + tap another	**Chain** the range: 1–4 plays 1, 2, 3, 4, 1, …
Hold **Duplicate** + tap a pattern	Copy the current pattern (all tracks) there
Hold **Clear** + tap a pattern	Clear that pattern on all tracks (its length stays)

TIP

Each track's part of a pattern keeps its own length, so tracks can still run polymetric lengths. A new, empty pattern takes the lengths of the current one.

SECTION 7

Tempo, Swing and Playback



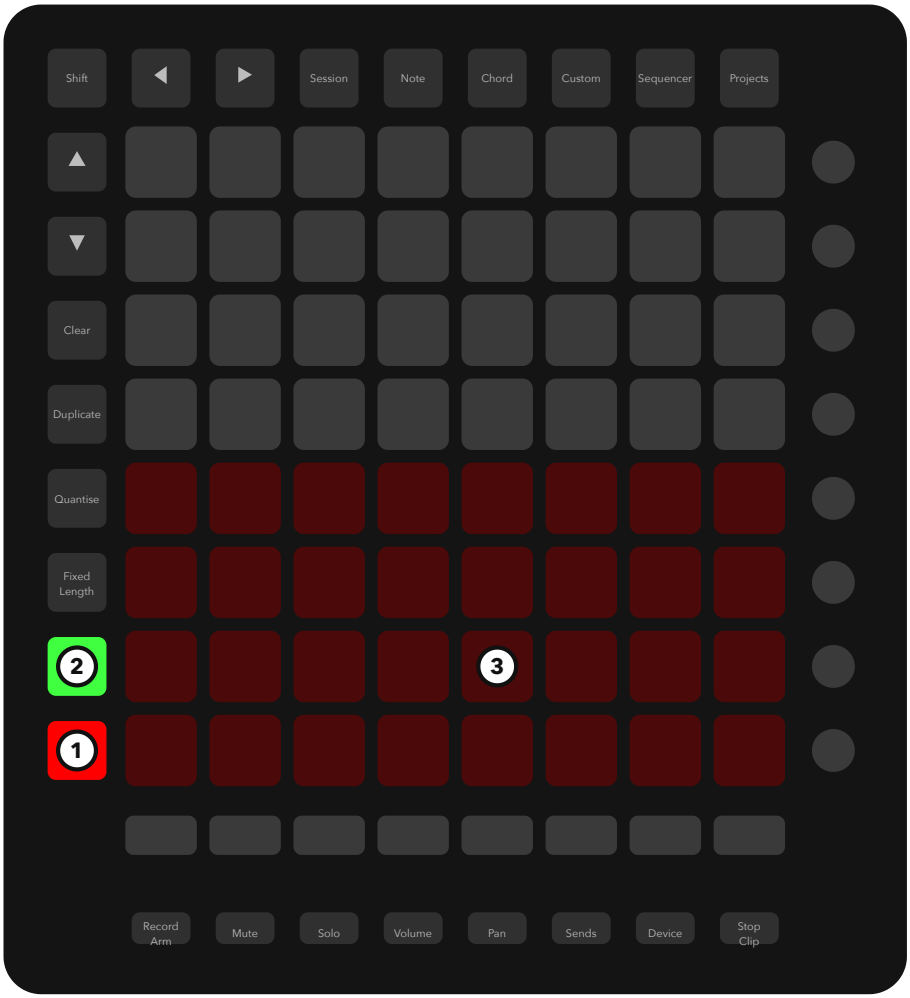
Shift held: 120 BPM on the note area, swing 53 %, Play green (internal clock)

1. **Shift.** Hold to see tempo, swing and the clock setting.
2. **BPM readout.** An orange bar for the hundreds (1–3 pads), then the tens and units in white.
3. **Tap.** Shift + Sends (printed *Tap*) is tap tempo.
4. **Swing.** The step area shows swing: step 1 = 50 % (straight) … step 26 = 75 %.
5. **Play.** With Shift: the external clock setting (see *MIDI Clock*).
6. **▲ / ▼.** With Shift: tempo.

Action	Result
▷	Start / stop
Shift + ▲ / ▼	Tempo +1 / −1 BPM (30–300)
Shift + **Fixed Length** + ▲ / ▼	Tempo +10 / −10 BPM
Shift + **Sends** (Tap)	Tap tempo: tap in time; the average of the last few taps sets the BPM. A 2-second pause starts over. The button flashes white on each tap.
Shift + a step 1–26	Swing 50–75 %

SECTION 8

Live Recording



Recording armed and playing

1. **Record.** Tap to arm (dark red); bright red while playing.
2. **Play.** Recording happens while the sequencer plays.
3. **Notes.** Play the note pads, or a keyboard on MIDI In or USB.

Recorded notes land on the **nearest step** of the selected track's current pattern, with their velocity and their held length as the gate: a note held over several steps plays for as long as you held it. Notes played together are recorded as a **chord** of up to 8 notes, keeping the loudest velocity.

A note played just ahead of a step is not replayed on that pass – you have already heard it.

Tap ○ again to stop recording.

Step recording (while stopped)

Arm ○ while the sequencer is **stopped** to enter notes one step at a time:

1. Tap ○ (dark red). A **white cursor** appears on step 1.
2. Play a note on the note pads or a keyboard. It goes on the cursor step, with its velocity, and the cursor moves to the next step when you let go.
3. Keep playing: each note fills the next step. For a **chord**, hold the notes together; the cursor moves on once you have released them all.
4. To leave a **rest** (or go back and redo a step), tap the step you want next: the cursor jumps there, and the steps in between keep whatever they had.
5. After the pattern's **last step**, Record disarms by itself and the cursor returns to step 1.

Recorded steps get the default gate (half a step); set it afterwards by holding the step. The cursor follows onto page 2 for steps 33–64.

> **TIP**
> While Record is armed and the sequencer is stopped, tapping a step only moves the cursor. Disarm Record to switch steps on and off again. Press Play at any time to hear the result; Record stays armed, so it then records live.

SECTION 9

MIDI Thru

A keyboard connected to **MIDI In** or to the Launchpad's USB MIDI port plays the **selected track**. Notes, aftertouch, controllers and pitch bend are re-sent on that track's output and MIDI channel, whatever channel the keyboard sends on. Select another track and the keyboard plays that track's instrument.

Program changes and bank select are not passed on, so changing presets on the keyboard never changes the sound of the synth the selected track plays.

A note-off always goes to wherever its note-on went, so changing track while holding keys never leaves notes stuck.

> **TIP**
> If your keyboard has its own sounds, turn its **Local** setting off so you only hear the selected track's instrument.

If the keyboard has MIDI Thru switched on, the sequencer's own notes and controllers come back to it. These echoes are recognised and dropped, so they do not loop or record twice.

SECTION 10

MIDI Clock

Sending clock

When the sequencer runs on its own tempo, it sends MIDI clock, start and stop to USB, MIDI Out and MIDI Out 2, so drum machines and arpeggiators can follow it.

Internal or external clock

By default the sequencer runs on its own clock and ignores any clock, start or stop arriving on **MIDI In** or the USB MIDI port; [▷] is **green**. Press [Shift] + [▷] to switch to following an external clock and back. While [Shift] is held, [▷] shows the setting:

▷ with Shift held	Setting
Green	Internal clock (default): ignore incoming clock, start and stop; run on and send the sequencer's own clock
Orange	Follow an external clock

Following an external clock

- [▷] flashes **orange**.
- The clock is passed on to both DIN outputs.
- Tempo controls and tap tempo have no effect.
- Half a second after the last clock pulse, the sequencer carries on with its own clock.

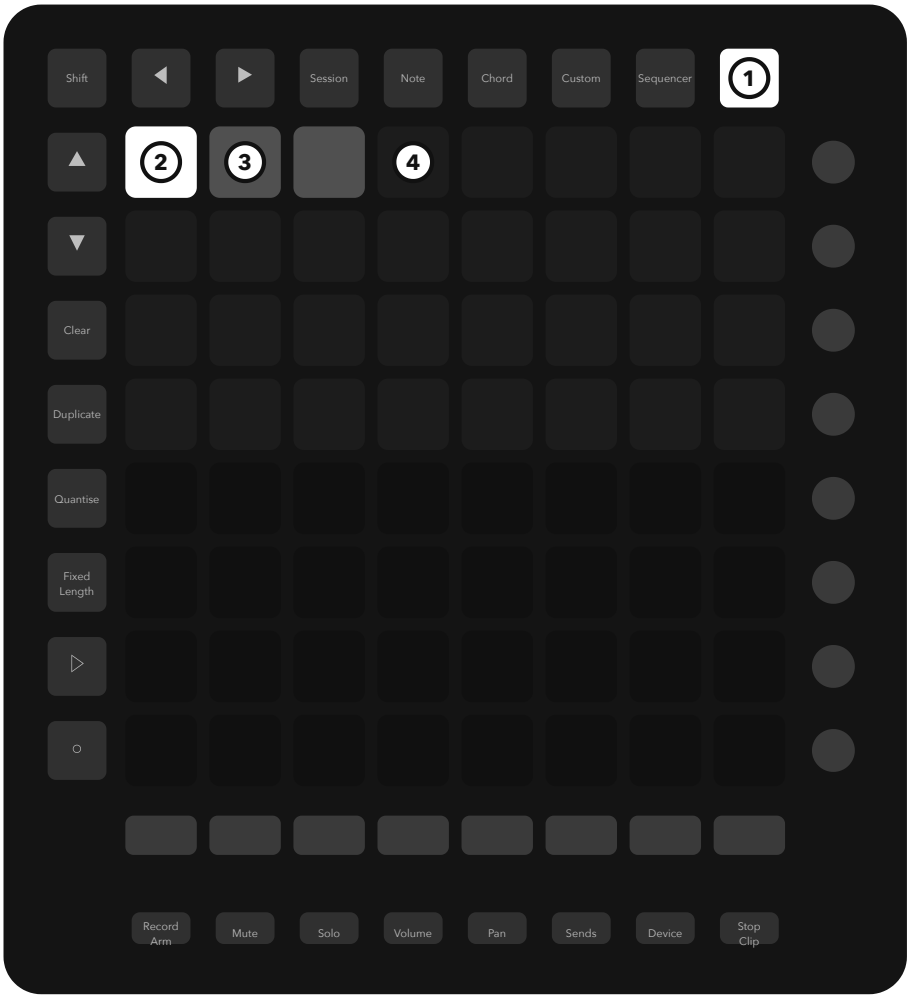
The setting is saved with the project; projects saved before it existed load on the internal clock.

> **TIP**
> Some synths (a Korg minilogue, for example) send a clock that stutters while they load presets. Only follow an external clock when you need to.

> **NOTE**
> A synth with MIDI Thru switched on sends the sequencer's clock straight back. The sequencer recognises its own clock and ignores it, so the tempo cannot run away.

SECTION 11

Projects



Projects held: project 1 current, projects 2 and 3 saved

1. **Projects.** Tap to save the current project (flashes white). Hold to see all 32.
2. **Current project.** White.
3. **Saved project.** Dim. Tap it (while holding Projects) to switch to it.
4. **Empty project.** Dark. Tap it to start a new, blank project there.

Switching saves the current project first. The Projects button is **green** when everything is saved and **amber** when there are unsaved changes.

A project holds everything: all tracks, the 16 patterns, chains, channels, outputs, transpose, step rates, tempo, swing and the external clock setting. The current project opens automatically after power-up.

Only the steps in use are stored. Each project has room for about 2,500 used steps; a project fuller than that cannot be saved.

SECTION 12

Quick Reference

Control	Tap	With Shift	Hold + …
Step pad	Toggle step	Set swing (steps 1–26)	Note pads = notes / chord; right column = velocity (+ Shift = probability); bottom row = gate
Note pad	Choose and hear note	–	–
Track button	Select track	–	Steps 1–16 = channel; steps 17–24 = step rate; note row 1 = output; rows 2–4 = transpose; ▲ / ▼ = channel
Mute / Solo	Arm: track buttons mute / solo at once	Arm: changes wait for the pattern start	–
Sends	–	Tap tempo	–
▲ / ▼	Octave	Tempo ±1 (±10 with Fixed Length)	–
▷ **Play**	Start / stop	Internal (green) / external clock (orange)	–
○ **Record**	Arm / disarm recording (stopped = step recording)	–	–
Fixed Length	–	–	+ step = pattern length
◀ / ▶	Steps 1–32 / 33–64	–	–
Clear	–	–	+ step = clear step; + track = clear pattern
Duplicate	–	–	+ step = copy it, then + steps = paste; with Patterns: copy pattern
Patterns	Open / close the pattern view: switch, chain, copy, clear	–	Same; closes when released
Projects	Save	–	Top four rows = 32 projects: switch
Note	Note mode (playback continues)	–	–

SECTION 13

Installing the Firmware

The sequencer is part of a custom build of the open-source CoreFW firmware (github.com/anthonyhfm/launchpad-core-firmware, GPL-3.0). No Novation firmware is supplied with it.

> **WARNING**
> This firmware is an early beta, tested on very few devices. Flashing your own Launchpad is at your own risk: the firmware may misbehave or lose your projects and settings, and an interrupted or failed update can leave the Launchpad needing recovery from the bootloader. The authors accept no responsibility for damage to your device or data. It is not Novation software and Novation does not support it.

Installing

1. Download the latest `.syx` file from github.com/cyberheater/Launchpad-Pro-MK3-Custom-firmware/releases, or build it yourself: `cargo lppmk3` in that repository (branch `lppmk3-sequencer`) makes `build/lppmk3/fw.syx`.
2. Unplug the Launchpad. Hold **Setup** while plugging the USB cable back in. The Launchpad starts in bootloader mode and a MIDI port with "Bootloader" in its name appears.
3. Send the `.syx` file to that port. Use CoreFW's `python3 tools/flash.py <file>.syx` (needs `pip install mido python-rtmidi`), the Mac-only `swift scripts/flash_syx.swift <file>.syx` from github.com/cyberheater/lpp-emu, or any SysEx tool (SysEx Librarian, MIDI-OX). Do not unplug the Launchpad while it is sending.
4. The Launchpad restarts with the sequencer firmware. Press **Sequencer** to open it.

Returning to the original firmware

Enter bootloader mode the same way and update the Launchpad with Novation Components.

> **NOTE**
> Projects are stored separately from the firmware, so updating the sequencer firmware should keep them. Projects saved by earlier sequencer versions load in later ones.